wrongly framed and criminals who were rightly exposed—and that wisdom was radiating from his speech and action. Singh, he told me, was to retire in three months.

Now I saw Sasi and Chandrasekhar leaving their room, must be for interrogation. They returned after a couple of hours. I knew it was my turn next.

AN EXPLOSION AND AN OUTBURST

'But why the resignation?'

No sooner than I returned to India, I found myself again in the vortex of the liquid-solid turmoil. Kalam was keen on me working with him on the SLV project, which at that time appeared the most promising project. Though I was not very happy at SSTC, which again worked more on solid propellants than liquid fuel, I found here a better opportunity to push for my pet project, which I was sure would one day take heavier satellites to space.

Kalam's SLV was on stream because it was approved as a project, while my liquid engine was still a concept, and hence categorized under research and development. Projects always got—and continue to get—more funds and human resources, while concepts remain just that till they are approved as workable projects. Sarabhai, my biggest moral support was by now no more—he was found dead in a hotel in Kovalam on 30 December 1971.

But I had faith in Satish Dhawan who had taken the place of Sarabhai, but Dhawan couldn't ask for more money—he could get it if he did—since I had nothing much to show on the ground for a liquid engine as a bright promise.

In mid-1968, the propulsion division was working at a feverish pace to launch the first multistage solid-fuelled sounding rocket named Rohini. During this period a small team consisting of T Sriram and A Chandran developed and tested the country's first indigenous liquid propellant engine